

Mentoring Schedule for a First-Year Mentee

Visit Number	Date	Activities & Topics to Discuss
1	End of April	- Assess the mentee's apiary site and ensure they have the proper equipment to get started. - Learn the mentee's beekeeping goals. - Discuss additional information resources for them to explore.
2	Mid May	- Demonstrate how to light a smoker. - Help install the mentee's nuc or package with them and feed syrup, explaining the hows and whys as you go along. - Discuss what to do if you get stung and how to reduce the likelihood of stings.
3	End of May	- Inspect the colony together. - Demonstrate how to use the hive tool and hold frames carefully. - Discuss and identify the following items/topics: wax construction, the three castes, brood stages, food stores, and basic aspects of honey bee social behavior. - Have the mentee practice identifying eggs.
4	Mid June	- Inspect the colony together. - Discuss <i>Varroa</i> mites and monitor for mites. Many beekeepers do not start to consider <i>Varroa</i> until the second year, believing young colonies will not accumulate high mite levels. This is not the case; many first-year colonies will develop high <i>Varroa</i> levels. Discuss treatment options, if needed.
5	Early July	- Inspect the colony together. - Discuss colony population growth and add a second deep hive body, if needed. - Discuss how to identify a colony preparing to swarm or a colony that has swarmed. Note that it is unlikely at this time (being a young colony in the month of July) that the mentee will observe signs indicating swarming.
6	End of July	- Inspect the colony together. - Discuss nectar flows in the region. - Discuss how to inspect the brood pattern to evaluate the queen and colony health.
7	Early August	- Have the mentee lead the colony inspection while you observe. - Evaluate honey stores in preparation for winter. - Discuss pests and diseases that can affect bees and the symptoms to look for. - Discuss colony thermoregulation and provide additional ventilation if needed.
8	Mid August	Discuss the honey harvest! Whether they have a super of honey or not, invite them to join your honey extraction endeavors.
9	Early September	- Have the mentee lead the colony inspection while you observe. - Ask them to demonstrate the skills they have developed so far: finding eggs, differentiating different types of food stores and brood stages, scraping burr comb, gently moving and replacing frames and hive bodies, etc. - Observe the mentee monitoring for mites; discuss treatment options if necessary.
10	Mid September	- Have the mentee lead the colony inspection while you observe. - Ensure the colony is ready for winter: begin feeding heavy syrup and pollen patties, if needed; merge weak colonies or those with failing queens. - Advise your mentee which wintering equipment to purchase.
11	Mid October	- Have the mentee lead the colony inspection while you observe. - Ensure the colony is still on track for wintering successfully. - Have the mentee monitor for mites. Discuss treatment options if necessary.
12	Mid November	- Winterize the colony together. - Provide information (or a beekeeping calendar) to your mentee regarding winter inspections, maintenance, and feeding. Be available for questions they may have during winter.